

PUSHED TO THE WATER

Fishermen communities resist and adapt with tourism development in Nha Trang

Nha Trang is my beloved coastal hometown, where I've watched things change over the years—some changes beautiful, others painful to see.

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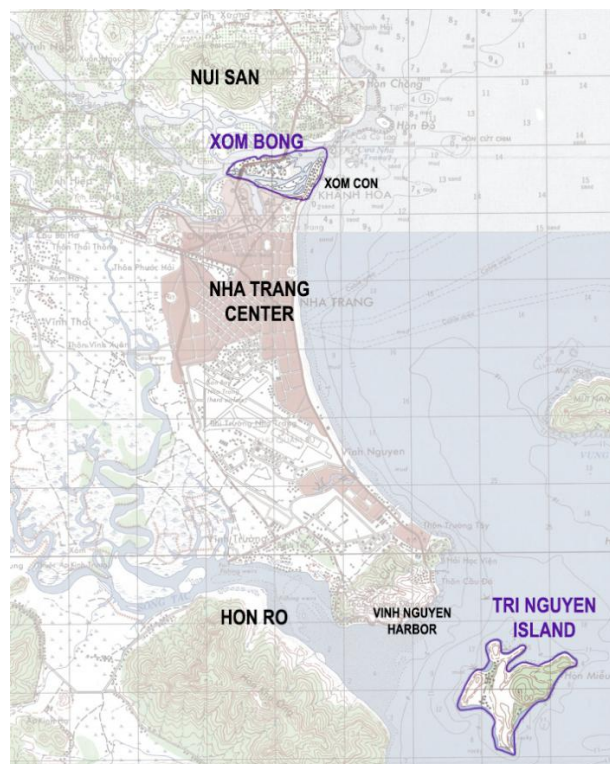
Urban Anthropology

The city and the body, The Informal City, People as infrastructure

Introduction

This paper aims to investigate the fishermen villages in Nha Trang, analyzes how fishermen adapt and resist government-led relocations in the city. By reviewing papers and news about the related issues, especially on how they bounce back to the water, I want to analyze the similarity of this case with the lectures from the course. Viewing through the urban anthropology lens, exploring the linkages between actors in the story, when people act as infrastructure, and how informality slowly gets its chances to exist side by side with the formality in the city.

Two examples are being studied in the paper: Xom Bong – also known as Nhat Tri islet – located on the Cai River in northern Nha Trang, and Tri Nguyen Island – located on the southeastern shore. They both present the long-time settlement of fishermen villages and are facing similar challenges: lack of attention from the government, storms, water rising, and the reduction of income from their traditional lifestyle. To understand how these two communities have evolved under similar pressures, this paper follows a chronological approach to examine their development side by side. While both tried their best to anchor down with expanding the households and informal construction within the community, one being viewed as a negative practice, the other one found alternative solutions on the water surface, that helped them gain the acknowledgement from the public and naturally their informality being accepted.



*Figure 1. Xom Bong, Tri Nguyen Island, and the settlements mentioned in Nha Trang
(Source: National Imagery and Mapping Agency 1983) (Edited by author)*

Historical foundations

Nha Trang – located in Khanh Hoa province – is a coastal city in Vietnam with a long history date back from the 17th century when the Nguyen Dynasty expanded their territory toward the south (Tu 1969). With its geographic character as a closed bay and multiple river streams, Nha Trang was ideally suitable for fishing and salt production (Tu 1969). Small fishermen villages were formed mainly on the waterfront, small islets and near shore islands. When Vietnam was going through the French colonial time and the Vietnam war, there was inland administration, and an airport developed in Nha Trang. But the city's fishery activities of the locals were still maintained and did not lose their character (Churchill and Vassal 1912). Throughout the urbanization progress from the late 1980 to early 2000s, and the recognition as an attractive tourism destination, Nha Trang then quickly transformed into a big construction site, where resorts and leisure services were built to accommodate the development needs.

Xom Bong community in the beginning had another area in the southeast – known as Xom Con – separated by a part of Cai River (Tu 1969). They were known for their character of a vibrant fishermen village, with houses and boats (Tu 1969). On the maps from the U.S. Army in Nha Trang, Xom Bong can be seen with existing structures, marked their long history as a community.

Tri Nguyen Island – original name was Hon Mieu – is one of the nearest shore islands in Nha Trang with only 1km away from the mainland. While it was not originally occupied by the local fishermen, this island was the shelter for other further northern provinces such as Quang Ngai, Binh Dinh, and Quang Nam's fishermen through storms. They then chose to start a new life here and built their own community. In 1970, the first attraction built on the island – a small aquarium – was owned by a local named Le Can (Anh 2024), and it mainly served for local tourism.

While both communities began as traditional fishermen settlements, the late 20th century brought significant changes due to urbanization and tourism

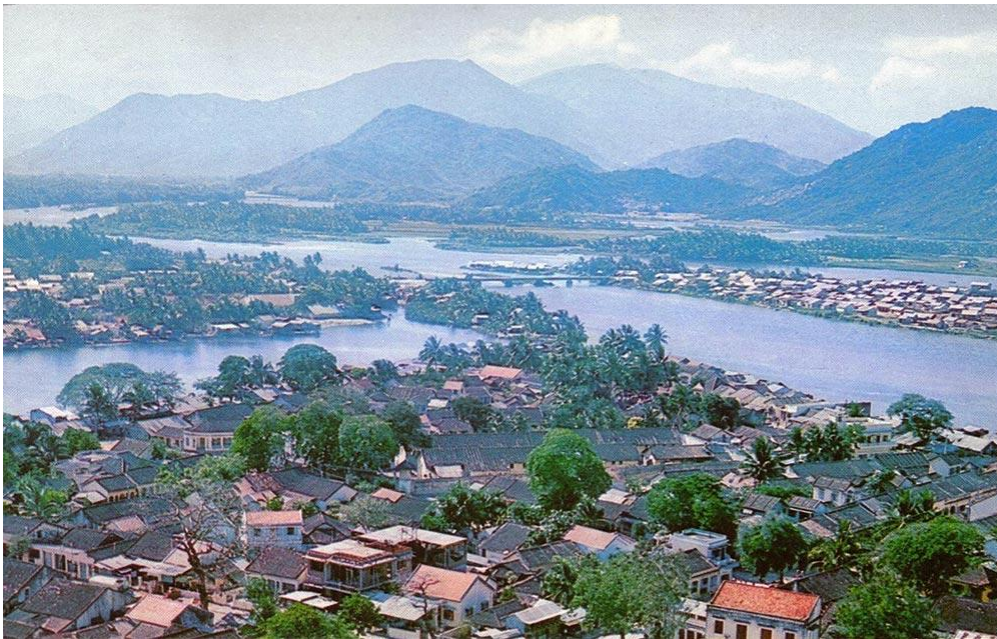


Figure 2. Xom Bong and Xom Con fishing village from above (Source: Jim Stewart 1960).

The Tug of War Between the Nha Trang Government and Fishermen Villages: Formal vs. Informal 1980s-1990s

As development and urbanization rise in Nha Trang, traditional fishermen villages started becoming a 'problem' within the city and requires to be relocated. These efforts began in the 1990s, with over 300 dwellers in Xom Bong were relocated toward Nui San (Hang 2024) – which further in land. This relocation occurred due to natural disaster, but since Nui San is still a nearby site, this relocation did not create much trouble for the dwellers.

In 1998, more residents of Duy Hai neighborhood in Xom Con – the southeast of Xom Bong – being relocated to settle in the Hon Ro 1 (Hang 2024) – on the riverfront in the south of Nha Trang. As the government said the purpose was to give them employment and entrepreneurial opportunities (Hang 2024). The fishermen traditional lifestyle with fishing, shellfish digging and shrimp catching requires them to live nearby the shore to get on the trips and making it easier to look after the boats. But by moving them into a different waterbody, they needed to seek away to find a new harbor for their boats, Hon Ro did not have its own harbor until 2001, so eventually they would come back again to Nhat Tri islet, where there is a safe spot to anchor down.

Tri Nguyen Island was located further away from the center of Nha Trang back then, so this island did not go through the relocating progress. But even with limited direct interference and growing pressures from nearby developments, the island was still rapidly developing with houses.

Although both communities faced urbanization during this period, their responses diverged due to their geographical positions and government priorities.

2000s

From early 2000s onward, the fishermen villages were not significantly being interfere by the government. But the rapid development of hospitality services in Nha Trang and the increase in tourists visiting the city without a clear public facility development plan synchronizing has led to many challenges in the city. Unemployment, lower education levels, lack of cultivated land, low or no compensation for people who had to move for infrastructure development has caused public anger, complaints, and denunciations (Hang 2024). This also contributed to the stubbornness of the locals when re-settlement was really needed for some situations. As the population growth, the demand for housing also increases. These fishermen villages did not stand outside of the flow, they have been getting more crowded. In the beginning of 2000s, the regulation and law related to planning in Vietnam has not yet covered every aspect, especially for a city like Nha Trang. The following consequences include loopholes for development and informal constructions to thrive.

Colin McFarlane in his paper about “Thinking with and beyond the informal–formal relation in urban thought” highlights the fluid boundaries between formal and informal structures. The informal housing and construction are not the only objects being viewed in this story, but also the economy and social activities of these communities. The communities found their way to get around the underregulated system, reoccupy the land if being moved away, and found new ways to make a living.

In 2004, Khanh Hoa province approved two projects including Cai River dikes and Urban beautification and environmental improvement in Nhat Tri islet (Baokhanhhoa 2008). The approval of these projects has stopped the approval progress of any official construction in Xom Bong community. This practice is commonly applied by the government to stop any opportunist trying to get more benefit from the land acquisition progress, but it did not stop the habitants to secretly building some temporary houses with light material such as wood and bamboo, crawling above the water. The pause for approval also forbidden other temporary houses that have been built before 2004 from improving the construction and having to "maintain the status quo". The overcrowded development and degrading of housing has turned their living habits further into an obstacle for tourism development.

Within the same timeline, Tri Nguyen Island has found a creative way to accommodate their situation. Starting from 2004-2005, there were 15-20 floating platforms appearing on the water (Nhandan 2003). These platforms' first purpose was to store caught fishes and shrimps from the fishing trips, and these then turned into fish and shrimp farms that they can easily take care of that cost them no land capital, just with self-built structures on water. Although there was also informal housing built along the waterfront of Tri Nguyen Island, there was no regulation for these structures, including the platforms on water hence no law and rule going against it. This was also the starting point transforming this traditional fishing village into an informal tourism destination.



*Figure 3. Xom Bong's informal housing on water
(Source: Phan Song Ngan)*



Figure 4. Tri Nguyen Island's informal housing and platforms on water (Source: Linda De Volder)

Tri Nguyen communities challenge these categories, reshaping informal systems to meet formal urban demands. Xom Con with similar informality movement, it went well in the early stage but soon be viewed as a slum. They both had the notion of working within the community together to build informal structures, the reactions from the public were not the same. While Xom Bong's informality became a symbol of neglect, Tri Nguyen's informal innovations gained public recognition and even indirect governmental approval.

The notion of people as infrastructure and the informality turned into economic opportunities

2010s

Fast forward to 2014, global warming led to higher tides and stronger waves on Cai River system. Xom Bong has crossed over 1400 households by this time. The dike project has been more than 10 years old, and Xom Bong had gone through over a decade of the houses being more degraded and shabbier. Many of the households are still waiting for compensation for the re-settlement. As the projects were hanging in there, no more public investment has been made to improve the living conditions for this islet. Lacking the water retention structures from the waves, many waterfront houses have crumbled down through the nights.



Figure 5. A part of Xom Bong after the high tide in 2015 (Source: Phan Song Ngan)

“Among the houses that were just destroyed by the waves, there were a few of my grandchildren's houses. You cannot renovate the house, and if you want to build a toilet, they will not let you. It is almost Tet, and I still have not seen any instructions on where to give me land to rebuild my house like they promised” - Ms. Huynh Thi Ky (Ngan 2015).

With 90% of the population works as fishermen or related jobs, Mr. Tran Quang Toan – another resident in Xom Con community – worried about what to find as their living job if they must move future away from their water (Ngan 2015).

Around early 2000s, the hidden aspects from a glorified tourism development plan of Nha Trang were revealed. Ilda Lindell's analysis of urban pressures underscores the tension between global competition and local poverty (2010). Nha Trang exemplifies this dynamic, where commercial interests overshadow marginalized communities' needs. From the government news, Xom Bong has been overcrowded and could not aligned with the national regulation. They blamed the informal constructions on the rivers has blocked out the water flows, the local roads were too small for firetrucks, ambulances, dump trucks and other public vehicles to access (Ky 2015). So, it was reasonable for them to force a new plan on the islet to ensure the environment and aesthetics of the city. This led to an ironic situation where Cai River dike project and the previous Urban beautification and environmental improvement project has not even started their relocating progress yet, but Khanh Hoa province's people committee has given the permission to a private investor to re-develop Nhat Tri islet. To get that new project on board, around 1200 households would have to relocate. With an ideal location and the character of isolated islet near the center of the city, the project's aim was not to improve the life for those habitants but to build new commercial centers, hotels, recreational villas, and hospitality services.



Figure 6. Nhat Tri islet approved development plan (source: Van Ky)

I was doing my bachelor graduation project at Tri Nguyen Island and did my fieldwork from 2016-2018. While talking to the locals and spending time with them, there are many more things behind than just visible expansion of these platforms and floating services.

Collaborative resilience on Tri Nguyen Island reflects the concept of people as infrastructure, with residents leveraging social ties for economic and infrastructural survival (Simone 2004). Some act as the middlemen, some as transportation for the tourists toward their main commercial space, each floating platform has their own invisible territories on water, there was no official rule or law, just a common understand between everyone. These platforms successfully show how profitable they are, a lot of other households on the island have also developed their platforms. The expansion of these on water informal structure could be easily seen from satellite images. Then they were not just simply seafood storage and farm anymore but turned into a new interesting destination for the tourists. They quickly transformed some part of the platform into a sitting area with tables and chairs as a simple restaurant.

They will have someone take your from Vinh Nguyen harbor or Tri Nguyen harbor directly to the platforms on a motorboat. The competition between these floating restaurants was not even a problem for the locals. During my trip, they explained to me roughly that the restaurants and boats will take turns getting customers and tourists. There was no argument or fight throughout my trips, it was simply just some vocal agreement of "I have gotten the last customer, you should take this one." The staff worked on the platforms mainly were family members of the owner, sometimes young kids from a different place came to join the

fishermen and then help with these tourism services. Furthermore, Karen Hansen and Mariken Vaa described the dual nature of informality – offering opportunities but also perpetuating exploitation. In Nha Trang, informal tourism ventures empower residents while exposing them to economic precarity. The questions came up to me during the trip back then were: “are they being treated fairly of getting the right social insurance from the owners?” “How did they maintain such a harmony community connection?” and “were there chances for a newcomer to join this nice informal system?” Thus, most, or even all the restaurants were running by families, with skill acquired outside the formal school system and unregulated and competitive markets, the risk of exploitation and no legal protection (Hansen and Vaa 2004) due to their tourism services are informal is significantly high. Besides that, the intermediaries’ income also heavily relied on the number of tourists who come to the island, there is no guarantee for their daily payment or any other different channel for them to make a living.



Figure 7. A boat carries both tourists and necessities to Tri Nguyen (Source: Nguyen Thanh Duong)



Figure 8. A floating restaurant in Tri Nguyen (Source: Le Phuc Loi)

I cannot reject the fact that to me, the emergence of floating fish cages on Tri Nguyen Island exemplifies the adaptive strategies of fishermen communities. These structures blend traditional practices with entrepreneurial innovation, creating a unique informal economy. This is also show out the thin line between informal and formal in the city (McFarlane 2019), when the majority of the public accept the informal

development and the city can gain benefit from it, Tri Nguyen was being praised as a beautiful image of traditional fishermen village, unlike the unfortunate case of Xom Bong.

However, this shift also introduces vulnerabilities on these fishermen communities. Global warming and disease outbreaks can decimate aquaculture yields, while fluctuating seafood prices and declining tourism revenues exacerbate economic instability. Even which location it was or when the event occurred, both these fishermen communities of Nha Trang presented the notion of people as infrastructure strongly when they had to work together through those common struggles. As Simone (2004) has written: “Even when actors do different things with one another in different places, each carries traces of past collaboration and an implicit willingness to interact with one another in ways that draw on multiple social positions.”

2017 marked a lot of events for both sites. A big fire happened in Xom Bong which affected over 70 households. The overcrowded informal settlement squeezing on the small islets with roads were too small to exist, and the construction was too close to each other have made it hard for them to stop the fire. After the fire incident, the Nha Trang government once again tried to relocate them to Hon Ro settlement, but until now, even though most of them have accepted the land, they still come back to Xom Bong and rent a different house to stay back on the islet again. Mr. Tran Khac Thach – one of the residents – said the relocated area is too far from their casual boats port, making it hard for them to move around (Nam and Pho 2020). The government indeed did build a harbor at Hon Ro in 2001 for the resettled residents, but now it also has been overloaded. The reason came from merging of Vinh Truong harbor to this harbor (Ngan 2023) – as the purpose to make space for the new commercial and tourism harbor at the other site. Consequently, that improved the concrete reasoning for Xom Bong residents to not move away.



Figure 9. The overcrowded situation of Hon Ro harbor (Source: Phan Song Ngan)

In this same year, Damrey Storm wiped away all the floating platforms in Tri Nguyen Island (Du 2023). After the storm passed, the community came together to dive down and tried to regain back what they could save from the seabed. Even the government cut off their electricity supply for ‘safety’, the fishermen just gathered and used their own generator on the boats to support the air pumps for the divers. The collaboration within the community through struggling time while being turned away from the government is a clear example to me that the city is made out of these communities – which are viewed as informal – and not the official government’s developments. Although some of the households had to turn back to their offshore fishing career to get through the days and rebuild the capital for their platforms. Within 1 year, in 2018, Tri Nguyen Island recovered almost like before Damrey has ever happened. As sound dreamy and perfect as it is, Tri Nguyen community indeed faced many challenges due to unforeseen diseases, sometimes they lose all what they have. When Covid came in 2019, the shrimp market crashed (Lam and Dinh 2022), tourists decreased from the pandemic, making the locals lose a lot of their money-making channels.

Despite differing circumstances, both communities demonstrated remarkable resilience in the face of environmental challenges and governmental neglect.

Post-2020s

In 2019, a great announcement from the government to Xom Bong, which stopped their misery for almost 2 decades. They will cancel the land acquisition to implement the 2015 project that was approved before. Their reason was that the profit from the project if successfully came through would still not even out for the compensation money toward all the affected households. Although the decision relieved Xom Bong community from unable to reconstruct their houses, from 2020 until now, when using the tag of “Xom Bong” or “Nhat Tri islet” to look for news, the titles are usually surrounded around “Flooding” and “High waves”. The houses located next to the shore crashed down every time there was a high tide, even though they needed to spend a lot of time and money to fix the collapsed structure, they would still rather spend all they have instead of moving away. Both men and women in Xom Bong were working together to rebuild their own houses or the neighbors’ house (Ngan 2019), and these community labors are commonly voluntary among Xom Bong. They built dikes and retaining walls, working together as the infrastructure of their own informal city.



*Figure 10. Mr. Nguyen Van Trung’s house in Xom Bong after the waves
(Source: Dinh Lam and Cong Dinh)*



*Figure 11. Xom Bong’s residents are building the new house’s foundation together
(Source: Dinh Lam and Cong Dinh)*

Furthermore, between both cases of Xom Bong and Tri Nguyen, the gender roles are very equal in the communities. Both men and women could be seen doing similar jobs through the day. For example: on Tri Nguyen Island, while men might take more heavy loading tasks, but they can be seen doing other similar

tasks such as net sewing or running the restaurants. In Xom Bong community, both men and women work together to improve the water retaining structures for their houses.



Figure 12. Net sewing at tailor houses on Tri Nguyen (Source: Nguyen Thanh Duong)



Figure 13. Both men and women work together to improve the structure in Xom Bong (Source: The Quang)

The idea of having people work together as a system of infrastructure within the city and then becoming the iconic character of the location like Tri Nguyen seems too good to be true. But these informal developments were somewhat accepted due to its successful and positive recognition from the public, what would be the alternative consequences if they were just the ‘informal’ living space of the locals who tries to anchor down to their old way of living like Xom Bong. The new adaptation in Tri Nguyen with floating restaurant on the water attracts a decent number of tourists to Nha Trang, helps them get a quiet nod of agreement from the government, although in public, there is still no regulation regarding this new way of lifestyle. But we also cannot deny the fact that the informality development without a direction and limit pushed them into being too overcrowded. The houses are mainly undocumented, not getting the basic public facilities and will the government then compromise and give them the needed benefits.

The future of city development should start from the locals

Are there alternatives for the city to develop while preserving local livelihoods and resisting overreliance on tourism? The international competition would further expose the city to pressures and imperatives (Lindell 2010), while the fishermen are still the main population of this city. Until now, the advantage of Nha Trang as a closed bay with little natural disaster like storms, high waves, and flood are being exploited as a great hospitality destination for accommodations, commercial, and other tourism services instead of productivities, farming, and nature reserving. When a fishermen village being widely known, they tend to then develop into a tourism attraction and soon filled with hostels, restaurants, spa... Xom Bong faced that

struggle, and Tri Nguyen also did not stand outside – as for now – on the island, there are at least five more private tourism service sites. And then, the following consequences are money thirsty developer jumped in, shallowing the land and once again pushing the locals away to halfhearted settlement, the cycle would then repeat itself until we have no more land to informally occupied.

Addressing the challenges of fishermen communities requires a multifaceted approach. Through the two cases of Xom Bong and Tri Nguyen, their informal activities between communities' actors showed how well they can work together without the involvement of the government. For those informal activities to exist in the city in the beginning, there is a relation between internal actors with the government, which might be complex, varied and temporal (Lindell 2010) but necessary and unable to ignore it. The city indeed still needs to be developed, with the relation between Nha Trang government and the fishermen community – which also not simply antagonistic (Lindell 2010) – collaborative and involving community input and respecting informal innovations, can bridge the gap between formal policies and lived realities. Due to the impacts of global warming, informal settlements near the water will need to relocate for both their own safety and the city's benefit.

“Does provincialising urban theory demand a rethinking and reinventing of the informal–formal relation, such as we see in this collection, or instead a more radical provincialising of that structure of thought so that it becomes a much more particular entry point to urban research than it currently is?” (McFarlane 2019)

In the end, Nha Trang's future depends on finding a way to grow while still valuing and protecting the lives of its local fishing communities. The stories of Xom Bong and Tri Nguyen show just how creative and resourceful these communities can be, working together in ways that often go unnoticed by formal systems. For the city to truly thrive, the government and locals need to work hand in hand, building trust and creating plans that reflect the realities of both urban growth and traditional livelihoods. The people – in this case – are truly the backbone structure in the progress of development for Nha Trang. With the added pressures of global warming, relocating informal settlements near the water will eventually be necessary – but it does not have to come at the cost of losing the culture and heart of these communities. By listening to and involving the people who have shaped Nha Trang's identity, the city can grow into a place that is not just a tourist hotspot, but a home that works for everyone.

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